Building Better Products for Everyone

As a Product Owner, your primary goal is to maximize the value of your product. You define the vision, manage the backlog, and represent the needs of your users. Accessibility is not just a technical requirement or a compliance checklist; it is a core component of product excellence that directly impacts value, market reach, and brand reputation.

This guide will show you how to champion accessibility as a strategic advantage and seamlessly integrate it into your product workflow.

The "Why" - Accessibility as a Business Imperative

Before diving into the "how," understand *why* accessibility is crucial for your product's success. It's not just "the right thing to do"—it's the smart thing to do.

- **Expand Your Market Reach:** Over one billion people worldwide live with some form of disability. By making your product accessible, you are unlocking a significant and loyal market segment that your competitors may be ignoring.
- **Enhance Brand Value:** An inclusive product demonstrates corporate social responsibility and builds a strong, positive brand image. Users notice and appreciate when a company cares about everyone.
- **Improve Everyone's User Experience:** Features designed for accessibility often benefit all users—this is known as the "curb-cut effect." Think of closed captions: designed for users who are deaf, but used by millions in noisy environments or when sound is off.
- **Mitigate Legal Risk:** Accessibility is a legal requirement in many countries (e.g., the Americans with Disabilities Act in the US, the European Accessibility Act). Proactive compliance protects your company from costly lawsuits and fines.
- **Boost Your SEO:** Many accessibility best practices, like using proper heading structures and image alt text, are directly aligned with search engine optimization best practices, improving your organic discoverability.

Understanding the Landscape (The Rules of the Road)

You don't need to be a technical expert, but understanding these two key standards will help you have intelligent conversations with your team.

WCAG: The Global Rulebook

The **Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG)** are the international standard. For a Product Owner, the most important thing to understand is the three levels of conformance, which you can use for prioritization and risk management.

- **Level A (The Basics - "Must-Have"):** These are the most critical issues. Failing Level A means certain users are completely blocked from using your product.
  - **Your takeaway:** A Level A bug is a **critical/high severity bug** and should be prioritized accordingly.
- **Level AA (The Industry Standard - "Should-Have"):** This is the target for most products. It ensures a high degree of accessibility and is the level most often cited in legal standards.
  - **Your takeaway:** Your product's accessibility target should almost always be **WCAG 2.2 Level AA**. This should be part of your product vision.
- **Level AAA (The Gold Standard - "Nice-to-Have"):** This is the highest level, often for specialized products or to demonstrate leadership. It can be high-effort.
  - **Your takeaway:** Aim for AAA where feasible, but focus your core efforts on achieving full AA compliance.

WAI-ARIA:

The "GPS" for Custom Components

You may hear your developers mention **ARIA**. Think of it this way: for standard HTML elements like buttons and dropdowns, screen readers already know what to do. But if your team builds a fancy, custom component, a screen reader is lost. **ARIA acts like a "GPS," adding labels and directions so assistive technology can understand what the component is and how to use it.**

- **Your takeaway:** When a new, complex UI component is proposed, your key question to the team should be, "How will this work for a screen reader user?"

The "How" - Integrating Accessibility into Your Workflow

Accessibility is most effective and least expensive when it's built in from the start, not bolted on at the end. Here's how to embed it into your product lifecycle.

In the Vision & Strategy Phase

- **Define Your Target:** Explicitly state your accessibility goal. Add "Our product will conform to WCAG 2.2 Level AA" to your product vision documents.
- **Create Personas:** Ensure your user personas include individuals with different

abilities (e.g., a persona with low vision, a keyboard-only user, a screen reader user). This keeps their needs top-of-mind.

In the Design & Discovery Phase

- **Ask for Annotations:** Require your UX/UI designers to annotate their designs with accessibility information. This includes:
  - The intended meaning of icons and images (for alt text).
  - The logical reading order for screen readers.
  - The designed keyboard navigation flow and focus states.

In Backlog Management (Your Most Powerful Tool)

- **Write Inclusive User Stories:** Frame stories from the perspective of different users.
  - *Standard Story:* "As a user, I can add an item to my cart."
  - *Inclusive Story:* "As a user who is blind, I want to be able to add an item to my cart using my screen reader so that I can make a purchase independently."
- **Add Accessibility to Your Definition of Done (DoD):** This is non-negotiable. A story is not "Done" until it is accessible. Your DoD should include items like:
  - ☑ Feature is fully usable with a keyboard.
  - ☑ All interactive elements have a visible focus indicator.
  - ☑ All images have appropriate alt text.
  - ☑ Feature has been tested with a screen reader (VoiceOver/TalkBack/NVDA).
  - ☑ Passes automated accessibility checks (e.g., Axe).
- **Create an "Accessibility Debt" Epic:** For existing products, perform an audit and create an epic to track and prioritize fixing existing accessibility issues. Use the WCAG levels (A, AA) to help prioritize the backlog.

In Development & QA

- **Factor in the Effort:** Coach your team to include the effort for accessibility in their story estimates. It's part of the work, not extra work.
- **Empower QA:** Support your QA team by giving them the time and tools to perform manual accessibility testing, especially with keyboards and screen readers. Treat accessibility bugs with the same severity as functional bugs.

Key Questions Every Product Owner Should Ask

You don't need to have the answers, but you need to ask the right questions to guide

your team.

- During Design Review:
  - "How would someone who can't see this color difference understand this information?"
  - "What does the focus state look like for this button?"
  - "What is the intended tab order for a keyboard user on this screen?"
- During Sprint Planning or Backlog Refinement:
  - "Have we included the effort to make this feature accessible in our estimate?"
  - "What are the acceptance criteria for accessibility on this story?"
- During Sprint Review:
  - "Can you demo this feature using only the keyboard?"
  - "Can you show me how this works with VoiceOver or TalkBack?"

Conclusion:

Inclusive Products are Successful Products

As a Product Owner, you sit at the intersection of business, technology, and user experience. Accessibility is not a separate stream of work; it is a fundamental quality that enhances all three. By embedding it into your vision, backlog, and definition of "Done," you will lead your team to build more robust, more user-friendly, and more successful products for a wider audience.